

**Regular Meeting
Monday, October 21, 2019
Medford School Committee
Medford City Hall**

Present: Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Ruggiero, Mr. Ruseau, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke, Superintendent Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Associate Superintendent Diane Caldwell, Assistant Superintendent Peter Cushing, Assistant Superintendent Kirsteen Patterson.

Roll Call and Salute the Flag - Meeting called to order at 7:02pm.

Approval of the Minutes of October 7, 2019 - Motion to approve offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Approval of Bills/Transfer of Funds and Approval of Payrolls - Ms. DiBenedetto asked about the student activity fund. She asked about Fillion Associates Other Supplies - revolving account. Ms. Patterson said she can look into what it covered. Ms. DiBenedetto asked about Groundmaster Corp Unclassified - Edgerly Field; pool chemical supplies. Motion to approve offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto.

Roll call vote.

7 - Affirmative

0 - Negative

Motion passes.

Motion to table community participation offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Report of Superintendent - Superintendent's Updates and Comments -

This past weekend featured perfect fall weather and many events were held outside that our students and their families could enjoy including the Harvest Your Energy Festival, the McGlynn Middle School PTO Yard Sale and the Brooks PTO Annual Fall Fest.

However, the weather last Thursday was not so great, with high winds and heavy rains. The Medford Public Schools are very grateful for the hard work of John McLaughlin and the Buildings and Grounds department, the Medford Police and Fire Departments, the City's Department of Public Works, and Eastern Bus Company who working together made it possible for the schools to safely remain in session that day.

Despite the Thursday weather, Medford High School and the Medford Vocational Technical High School held 8th Grade Open House. High school student ambassadors led tours all over the campus, including the Science Labs, the Fine Arts Department, the Library Media Center, the Vocational Technical programs, and the athletic wing, where all of the sports teams were present. I am glad that so many of our rising 8th graders and their families were able to attend this important informational session.

I am pleased to announce that two of our Medford High School students, Lang and Qing Cheng, twin sisters, each received \$500 from the Pace Family and the FAA-USA, Federazione Associazioni Abruzzesi to celebrate Italian Heritage Month.

I am pleased to announce that due to the efforts of Molly Laden, our Director of Technology, Library and Media, who applied for a makerspace grant through the Verizon Foundation, the Medford Public Schools will be awarded \$10,000. This grant will enable Medford High and the Medford Vocational Technical High to create a shared STEAM makerspace to be used by core academic subjects and CTE programs that will enable academic and career preparation connections. Students and teachers in multiple programs and courses will use the makerspace to plan, design, create and synthesize projects using interdisciplinary project-based learning to solve and engage in STEAM activities. This is a long time goal of this department and the Medford Public School District. Molly will be in attendance at our next meeting to explain the process in more detail. In the meantime, we thank Verizon for choosing us and commend Molly for applying for the grant.

Recently, C.A.S.IT, Inc. in collaboration with the Sons of Italy, welcomed students in honor of Italian American Heritage Month, which is the month of October. Students were invited to create a booklet on the 500th anniversary of the death of Leonardo Da Vinci, which celebrated his life and his works. The winners of the essay contest were hosted at this event. C.A.S.IT, Inc. is a non-profit educational and professional organization that promotes Italian language and culture in public and private schools throughout New England. Medford took home 2nd and 3rd place awards.

2nd place – Brooks Elementary School, Fifth Grade. The students were awarded \$200. The students who participated were: Sofia DiFronzo, Amy Radziszewski, Jack Holtslag, Becky Casey, Evie Glionna, Ben Tuco, Emet Chasteen, Alex Civitareale, Lucas Dyou-Goulden, Jayden Giant, gigi Kohls, Makayla Maccarone, Travers Moodie, Michael Morando, Reid Pacini, Reanna Panico, Selina Shrestha, & Alex Yamamoto. Special thanks to the teachers: Jennifer Conti, Laura Odoguardi and Principal Suzanne Galusi.

3rd place – McGlynn Elementary School, Fifth Grade. The students were awarded \$150. The students who participated were: Loghan Aguilar, Emily Chinas Romero, Nellie Davis, Jemimah Diligent, Maiylynn Grace, Sophia Mihelis, Jonathan Pereira, Jose Sola Lemus, Cooper Su, Jonathan Wright, Mahidul Bary, James Cluggish, Feka Desir, Abraham Eldeeb, Nicole Lopes, Jaiveer Pabla, Carissa Purifory, Shayla Sousa, Kyanna Tran, & Ivan Zheng. Special thanks to teacher Debby Notaro and Principal Diane Guarino.

On Wednesday, October 23rd, Medford High School hosts both the Planning for College Information Session – for students with IEPs and 504s and their parents/guardians at 5:30 PM, in the 3rd Floor Science Lecture Hall, with the Annual College Fair immediately following in the MHS Gym at 6:30pm.

Motion to resume Community Participation offered by Ms. Kreats, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto, motion passes.

Community Participation - Cheryl Rodriguez, 281 Park Street - My daughter is at the McGlynn and rides bus 2. There is not enough space on the bus for the students. The bus driver dropped students off inappropriately. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - This is the first I am hearing of this. I will follow up with the bus company tomorrow.

Recommendation to Approve Grant for Headstarting Turtle Project - Ivy Carnabucci - The Morton and Spapperi Family Foundation has selected to fund this project for Medford High School this year, for an amount of \$2,205.72. Motion to approve offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Kreatz.

Roll call vote.

7 - Affirmative

0 - Negative

Motion passes.

Report on First Annual Medford Vocational Technical High School Fundraiser - Chad Fallon - We would like to host a dinner to fundraise for the school including a one-day liquor license. We can use it as an opportunity to highlight the strengths of our programs. Motion to approve offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Kreatz, motion passes.

Recommendation to Approve Creation of New Revolving Account: MVTHS Fundraising - Kirsteen Patterson - Motion to approve offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Kreatz.

Roll call vote.

7 - Affirmative

0 - Negative

Motion passes.

Report on New Hires, Retirements, and Personnel - Kirsteen Patterson - We are presenting the most accurate and up-to-date list as of today. We have a significant amount of movement and we have a small office that handles a large amount of movement. It is an ongoing issue. Mr. Ruggiero - I am concerned that our nutritionist has resigned. Are we hiring a new nutritionist? Ms. Patterson - Not at this time. Mr. Ruggiero - I think that should be a priority. I would like to be updated on when we will be filling the role. Ms. Van der Kloot - I noticed quite a few people have been brought on after the start of school. How do we make sure they are up to date? Ms. Patterson - We rely on their department head or building principal. The para group does not go through the rigorous process the teachers do. Ms. Van der Kloot - Do they get updated on emergency plans? Ms. Patterson - That is building based, not HR. Ms. Van der Kloot - I noticed we hired a lot of people in the After School program. I would like an update on the After School program in the future. There is a teacher on leave at the Andrews and the teacher replacing them is certified, but not in science. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - That is true. The replacement teacher is not certified, but has worked with science. He was building-based at the Andrews. We will be revisiting that. Ms. Van der Kloot - Please provide us with an update. Please monitor the new teacher carefully. Ms. DiBenedetto - How many open positions do we have in the district and what are they? How many people are on leaves and what job titles are we looking for? Ms. Patterson - All open positions are posted on our website and most long term positions have been filled. We leave some open, such as daily subs, but most have been addressed. Please visit our site, it is linked to from the Medford Public Schools website and they can apply at any time. Ms. DiBenedetto - It includes temporary and long-term positions and coverage for leaves? Ms. Patterson - Yes. Ms. DiBenedetto - I agree with my colleague that I am concerned that new staff be trained on emergency plans and that there should be onboarding training on that. And everyone including volunteers should be CORIed. Ms. Patterson - Of course. Ms. DiBenedetto - The teacher on leave at the Andrews is 8th grade and that is a testing year, they need the support. Were any changes made to the bus schedules so students can eat breakfast? Ms. Patterson - We informed them that students should be released so they can have breakfast. I want to ensure everyone that the nutritionist is not a required position, we are in compliance. We are serving scratch breakfast, there are lots of options and we are making a big effort to make it successful. Mr. Ruseau - If a teacher is not certified in a discipline, that is reported to DESE, correct? Ms. Patterson - It depends on the length of time. Motion to accept the report and place on file offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Mr. Ruggiero, motion passes.

Report on Dyslexia Screening Tools Update - Diane Caldwell - The presentation and report give a comprehensive explanation of the programs that will be piloted at the elementary schools to screen for dyslexia using Lexia Rapid at Brooks, Roberts, and McGlynn Elementary Schools and MAP Growth at Columbus Elementary. Ms. DiBenedetto - When will this be communicated to

parents? Ms. Caldwell - We will communicate to parents throughout. Normally when we do assessments we do not inform parents. We might inform them when we see a need for intervention. Teachers can share the results of the assessments when they do conferences at the time the report cards come out. Ms. Mustone - Since Lexia is letting us use it for free, is that too good to be true? Ms. Caldwell - It costs \$7 per student if we pay for it. Lexia Core-5, the intervention tool is \$40 per tool. It is supposed to appeal to the state so the state adopts it. Ms. Mustone - Does MAP or Dibels offer an intervention tool? Dr. Chiesa - No. Ms. Mustone - Are we using Lexia because it is free or because it is good? Dr. Chiesa - It is a very strong program. Ms. Mustone - Are we on the hook for it? Ms. Caldwell - We have to wait for DESE to make a call at the end of the year. Ms. Campbell - DESE put these screeners on their list that they wanted piloted. They applied for a grant and they asked that we pilot these programs. Mr. Ruggiero - Is dyslexia on a bell curve in the RIT score? Ms. Ciampoli - It identifies red flags, but does not diagnose dyslexia. It would identify weaknesses. Ms. Campbell - The screeners identify students who are at risk for reading difficulty. The first step is doing interventions in general education. If we intervene early we can help children before they get to the point of requiring a diagnosis of dyslexia. Mr. Ruggiero - Do you have someone who knows how to handle students with dyslexia? If you see five red flags do you bring in interventions or do you tell the parents they need help outside of school? Dr. Chiesa - There are many reasons why a child may be successful or not on a screener. If a Kindergartner is unsuccessful on a screener they may not know their letters yet. We look for growth with interventions and if we see a lack of growth then we know it is a deeper concern. It is almost a misnomer to call it a dyslexia screener because it is a literacy screener. Mr. Ruggiero - We are screening for reading ability. If you give a student this test and they do not do well intervention is applied, when does the next screener happen? Dr. Chiesa - We do fall, winter, spring, and in between we do other quick assessments. We do progress monitoring. Mr. Ruggiero - Some children slip through the cracks. We can do a better job earlier. What is the educational road map? Dr. Chiesa - It will be based on the individual, child to child. Ms. Campbell - We would bring the family in at that point. Is the child responding to interventions? The child will be assessed for special education if that is necessary. This is a universal screener to see where a child is starting. An IEP is not a first step. Mr. Ruggiero - We want to avoid a situation where a parent has to pay an outside consultant for treatment for their child because the school missed it. We have a new roadmap. Ms. Caldwell - We are making progress. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - This is new. We are working cooperatively with the state. These screening mechanisms were not available to us before as they are now. If a teacher has a student displaying difficulty we would not allow that student to struggle for 8 or 9 months. However, we would not automatically place a student on an IEP. We try to do the least-restrictive measures possible in the beginning before putting a student on an IEP unnecessarily. We are partnering with Lexia and when DESE makes its decision we will be in a strong position to have had solid training over the course of this year to be able to identify and work with those students. We take our final marching orders from the state, but we are prepared to hit the ground running, we are

doing it early and next year we will be in a strong position. Ms. Van der Kloot - How do we group readers today? Dr. Chiesa - Every child is in a group, doing computerized work either because they are gifted and need more challenges, or because they are struggling. It is individualized. It can remove stigma.

Motion to notify parents about results of screenings offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruggiero, motion passes.

Mr. Ruseau - Do these have technology requirements that we can meet? Ms. Caldwell - Yes. Mr. Ruggiero - Is data collected? Ms. Campbell - The program is HIPAA compliant.

Motion to accept the report and place on file offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

New Business - Vote on Cleaning Company Contract - RFP Summary and Recommendation - Ms. Patterson presented a summary of 11 companies that submitted proposals for cleaning contracts. Mayor Burke - Empire was not deemed appropriate prior to the bid. Ms. Patterson - Correct. Mr. Ruseau - Do the employees of Compass receive wages and benefits similar to our custodial staff? Ms. Patterson - We do not dictate their wages. They are CORI checked, but we do not dictate their wages. I can share the RFP. It is not the intent of the vendors to mistreat their staff. Their commitment to their staff on an ongoing basis was one of the criteria measured in the RFP. Ms. Mustone - We take their word from their RFP that they pay their employees a living wage? Ms. Patterson - We do not request their time sheets. If there was an issue we would want to be notified. Mayor Burke - They are outside unions. We got a three page letter confirming that staff receive a living wage. Ms. Mustone - Can we write into the RFP that we require their staff be paid a living wage in the future? Ms. Patterson - It could be cost prohibitive. Ms. Van der Kloot - What is the increase from the last contract? Ms. Patterson - 4%. I budgeted 3.5% so we are on track. I will share the RFP.

Motion to table voting on this until School Committee has the RFP in hand offered by Mr. Ruggiero, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto.

Roll call vote.

2 - Affirmative: Mr. Ruggiero, Ms. DiBenedetto

5 - Negative: Ms. Mustone, Ms. Kreatz, Mr. Ruseau, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke

Motion fails.

Ms. DiBenedetto - I would like to make a motion that we review hiring Medford people to clean instead of hiring a cleaning service. Ms. Van der Kloot - It would make more sense that prior to the next contract we do a study. Ms. DiBenedetto - I would like to make a motion that this

contract be one year instead of three years. Mayor Burke - We requested a three year contract so that would nullify this process.

Motion for a cleaning cost analysis by December offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Motion to Approve Cleaning Contract offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Mr. Ruseau.
Roll Call Vote.

6 - Affirmative

1 - Negative: Mr. Ruggiero

Motion passes.

Motion to enter executive session offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Mustone.

Roll Call Vote.

7 - Affirmative

0 - Negative

Motion passes.

Exit to executive session 9:01pm.